provision to prevent the federal government from borrowing money and going into debt. Times haven't changed; that's still a glaring omission in the Constitution.

In the past fifty-nine years, there have been only eight scattered years in which the budget was balanced. For fifty-one of those years there was a deficit, and, as I pointed out, for fifty-five of those years the Democrats controlled the House of Representatives.

Every year that I was president, I asked Congress for a constitutional amendment that would require the federal government—like any well-run household or business—to balance its budget. But Congress (and I concede there was opposition to it on both sides of the political aisle) wouldn't sit still for this infringement on its spendthrift ways. There was some important progress: The spending limits imposed on Congress by the Gramm-Rudman-Hollings law have helped curb its extravagance. But never underestimate the willingness of congressmen to circumvent their own rules, or the public will, in the pursuit of their enthusiasm to spend other people's money.

I don't put all the blame on Congress. Part of the problem rests with political realities. It's a fact of life that running for political office in this country is very expensive; once in office, few incumbents want to surrender their seats in Congress, so they often turn to the special interests, who want special consideration from them, for the money to finance their campaigns. Then, after the election, they repay the favors—with the taxpayers' money.

That's one of the reasons I think presidents need a line-item veto authority. I had it when I was governor of California, and governors in forty-two other states have it as well. When the state legislature sent me a budget, I could take a blue pencil and reduce spending on individual items to a level taxpayers could afford. If there was something laudable about a piece of legislation, I could sign it but veto